



A planner for the weeks after birth

My Postpartum *Plan.*

A map, not a rigid plan, for the people who will hold you, feed you, and help you rest while you mother your new baby.

"We believe that every birth can be a space of dignity, connection, and power. The same is true of the days that follow."

MARY'S HANDS NETWORK

THIS PLAN BELONGS TO

Your name

ESTIMATED DUE DATE

Month, day, year

PARTNER / CO-PARENT

Name

DOULA / SUPPORT PERSON

Name

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A Map, Not a Rigid Plan.

The first six weeks after birth, sometimes called the fourth trimester, are a sacred and ordinary time. Your body is healing. Your baby is learning the world. Your household is finding a new rhythm. This planner exists so you do not have to figure it out alone, and so the people around you know how to help.

Fill it out with your partner, your doula, or a trusted friend. Return to it often. Change it freely. The goal is not to predict every detail, it is to start the conversations that protect your rest, your healing, and your peace of mind.

HOW TO USE THIS PLANNER

Each section asks a few short questions. Answer what you can, leave what you cannot. Share completed pages with the people who will support you. You can fill it out on a screen and print it later, or print it now and write by hand.

WHAT DOULAS WILL TELL YOU

Sleep, food, and trusted help are not luxuries. They are the foundation of your recovery. Plan for them with the same care you planned for the birth itself.

A Word On Asking For Help

Accepting help is a strength, not a weakness. You are not meant to recover from birth in isolation. The people who love you want to be useful. This plan helps them be useful in the ways that actually serve you.

Your Three Postpartum Priorities

ONE · REST

A minimum of five hours of uninterrupted sleep, and a place to lie down without being needed, every single day.

TWO · NOURISHMENT

Warm, simple, frequent meals you do not have to cook, and water within reach wherever you are feeding the baby.

THREE · PRESENCE

A short list of trusted people who can sit with you, hold the baby, and help you notice when something feels off.

The First Thing To Decide

If today is hard, who is the first person I will call?

Name

PHONE ()

SECTION ONE

Recovering, Body And Mind.

Sleep And Rest

Why Sleep Is The Plan

Getting adequate sleep is one of the most important ways to protect your postpartum mental health. A minimum of five hours of uninterrupted sleep, or minimally interrupted if you are breastfeeding a newborn, is required for the brain to do its overnight repair work.

1. How will you obtain a minimum five hours of sleep? Will a support person wake to feed and change the baby?

2. Where will the baby sleep at night?

Co-sleeping in your bed, in a bassinet next to the bed, in a crib, in his or her own room.

Physical Recovery

1. What is most important to you about how you physically recover from birth?

2. How will you achieve these things?

Sleep, self-care, support, therapy, physical therapy, gentle movement, and so on.

Mental And Emotional Recovery

List symptoms you have experienced in the past that signaled your mental health was declining. Name a partner or support person you trust to share this list with, so they can help you watch for the signs that you may need additional support.

PAST WARNING SIGNS I KNOW IN MYSELF

PERSON I WILL SHARE THIS WITH

SECTION TWO

Feeding And Caring For Baby.

Infant Feeding

1. How do you plan on feeding your baby?

Breastfeeding, formula feeding, exclusive pumping, combination, undecided.

2. If you are breastfeeding, do you have support?

If this is your first time, plan on getting some sort of support, an IBCLC, a peer counselor, a friend who has nursed before.

3. What are your expectations for feeding the baby? Feeding cues? Schedule?

Doula Tip

Newborns feed eight to twelve times in twenty-four hours. That is normal, not a sign of low supply. The first two weeks are about responding to cues, not building a schedule.

Care For Infant

Can you plan a flexible schedule for who will be responsible and when tasks will be completed? Include feeding, diapers, baths, and other anticipated baby care.

TASK	WHO IS RESPONSIBLE	WHEN
1. Daytime feeds		
2. Overnight feeds		
3. Diaper changes		
4. Baths		
5. Soothing & holding between feeds		
6. Other		

SECTION THREE

Help, At Home.

Care For Siblings And Pets

1. Who will care for siblings during the postpartum period? What care will be needed?

2. Who will care for pets?

In-Home Help

Who will help with home tasks during the postpartum period? List partners, relatives, friends, nannies, postpartum doulas, or anyone else who has offered.

TASK	WHO IS HELPING	HOW OFTEN
1. Laundry		
2. Dishes		
3. Meal preparation		
4. Home cleaning		
5. Errands & shopping		
6. Other		

A Practical Note

When someone says "let me know if you need anything," answer with a specific task from this list. Vague offers rarely turn into help. Specific asks almost always do.

SECTION FOUR

Feeding The Household.

Meals And Food

1. What meals can you make ahead and freeze for the weeks following birth?

2. Who will help with meal preparation after the birth, including who will cook when it is not the mother?

3. Nutritious and affordable take-out and delivery options near you

4. Quick snacks and drinks within reach of where you will feed the baby

Visitors And Guests

What is our policy for visitors?

Calling ahead, holding the baby, hand-washing, and so on.

FIRST WEEK

SECOND WEEK

THIRD WEEK

0

0

0

Expected visitors per week, a target you can adjust day-to-day.

Your Right To Set Boundaries

It is okay to set boundaries, to plan to limit guests, and to decline visitors if you would like. You also have the right to ask visitors to wash their hands, to help with chores, or to limit their time. A short visit that helps is a gift. A long visit that watches you serve coffee is not.

SECTION FIVE

The Two Of You.

A new baby reorganizes a relationship. Talking honestly about expectations now, while you are rested, makes the days when you are not far easier to navigate.

Partner Relationship

It is important for our relationship that we ...

AS THE MOTHER, I EXPECT THE PARTNER'S ROLE TO BE

AS THE PARTNER, I EXPECT THE MOTHER'S ROLE TO BE

Our Greatest Concerns

Name the worries out loud. Worries shared with someone you trust have less power than worries kept to yourself.

MOTHER'S GREATEST CONCERNS

PARTNER'S GREATEST CONCERNS

SECTION SIX

Roles, At A Glance.

A single page you can hand to anyone in the house, anyone visiting, anyone wondering how to be useful. One question per row, one name to call.

WHO WILL	PRIMARY PERSON	BACKUP
1. Care for the baby		
2. Care for the siblings		
3. Do the cleaning		
4. Do the cooking		
5. Do the laundry		
6. Be at home		
7. Do the shopping		
8. Run the errands		
9. Transport siblings		
10. Care for pets		
11. Other		

A Note On The Word "Primary"

Primary does not mean only. It means the person we ask first, so the mother does not have to assign every task in the moment. Backups exist because life happens, and so the answer is never "no one."

SECTION SEVEN

Postpartum Mental Health.

Postpartum mood and anxiety disorders are common and they are treatable. The list below is not a diagnosis, it is a watchlist. Read it now, when you feel well, so you and the people who love you can recognize the signs later.

Symptoms To Watch For

If you or your support system notice any of these, consider contacting a therapist, a psychiatrist, or your OBGYN for additional support.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Feeling hopeless, not looking forward to things as much as usual | ☐ Repetitive scary thoughts that cause concern, or behaviors to prevent something bad from happening |
| ☐ Blaming yourself excessively when things go wrong | ☐ Anxiety that gets in the way of doing things |
| ☐ Not being able to stop worrying | ☐ Frequently feeling panicked |
| ☐ Difficulty keeping up with usual tasks | ☐ Frequently feeling irritable |
| ☐ Unable to sleep, even when the baby sleeps | ☐ Considering harming yourself or taking your life |
| ☐ Feeling miserable or frequently overwhelmed | |

If You Are In Crisis

If you are considering ending your life, please contact the Statewide Crisis Line at **855-CRISIS-1**, call **911**, or allow a loved one to take you to the nearest emergency room. You are not a burden. You deserve immediate care.

People I Trust In A Crisis

Three names you can hand to your partner or your doula. The names you would want called for you, even if you could not ask in the moment.

ONE

Name

Phone

Relationship

TWO

Name

Phone

Relationship

THREE

Name

Phone

Relationship

SECTION EIGHT

Important Contacts.

Your Care Team

OBGYN

Name & practice

Phone

PEDIATRICIAN

Name & practice

Phone

HOSPITAL

Hospital name

Phone

PSYCHIATRIST

Name

Phone

THERAPIST

Name

Phone

LACTATION (IBCLC)

Name

Phone

Support Groups

Local groups, online communities, mom circles you trust

Crisis Hotlines

PSI

Maternal Mental Health Hotline · **1-800-944-4773 (4PPD)**

Text the same number for support by message.

988

Suicide & Crisis Lifeline · **988**

Call or text from anywhere in the United States.

CRISIS TEXT

National Crisis Text Line · **Text HOME to 741741**

Free, confidential support, twenty-four hours a day.

LOUISIANA

Statewide Crisis Line · **855-CRISIS-1**

Online Resources

PSI

Postpartum Support International · **postpartum.net**

Online support groups for new mothers, dads & partners, NICU parents, loss, and more.

COUNSELING

Ready Nest Counseling · **readynestcounseling.com**

New Moms Group, Toddler Moms Group, Working Moms Group.

MHN

Mary's Hands Network · **maryshandsnetwork.org**

Volunteer community doulas across Southeast Louisiana, at no cost to families.



"It is a holy and sacred role to be a support, a guide, a servant, and a doula. It is a gift and a treasure that we get to be in that space, and it is a gift and a treasure for that woman."

MADELINE LEBLANC, RN, MHA, IBCLC · FOUNDER

We made this plan together, before the baby came, knowing it would change. We will return to it often, change it freely, and remember that the goal is not to do everything. The goal is to take care of one another.

MOTHER · SIGNED

PARTNER · SIGNED

DATE

Month, day, year

DOULA · WITNESSED